

Does the system of capitalism amplify the worst aspects of human nature?

Philosophy coursework - critical analysis of a non-philosophical prompt

Word count: 1999/2000



Description of stimulus:

My stimulus images are from the Oscar-winning 2019 film ‘Parasite’ by Korean Director Bong Joon Ho. The images are taken from an important scene within the film in which the city is experiencing an intense rainstorm. The images display the lives of two families of differing socioeconomic backgrounds and the effects the rainstorm had on them. The first image displays the daughter of the working-class Kim family sitting in the flooded basement home, cut to the second image which displays the blissful tranquillity of the wealthy Park family as they experience the same weather conditions.

Word count: 96

Essay:

The stimulus depicts two images of different families at a simultaneous point in time. One exhibits a sombre existence amid darkness, while the other exudes a serene state of tranquillity; Joon Ho purposefully crafts the striking contrast in the scenes to lay bare the escalating wealth disparity prevailing in South Korea. On watching this scene, observers might find themselves appalled by the coexistence of wealth and serenity in one family juxtaposed against the destitution and loss endured by another during a shared natural calamity. Some would argue that it is the principles of capitalism, characterized by private ownership of the means of production, profit motive, and economic freedom¹ that impede such selflessness; yet some would argue the principles of capitalism are just a reflection of our human nature. Ergo, this stimulus links to the question of whether or not capitalism amplifies the worst aspects of human nature. To explore the differing arguments, I will explore the perspectives of human nature from the prominent philosophers; Thomas Hobbes, Jean Jacques Rousseau, Karl Marx and Adam Smith. By analyzing their perspectives, I aim to assert that human nature does possess self-interested propensities, however it also possesses many positive aspects, yet the system of capitalism only exemplifies the worst aspects of human nature - particularly that of selfishness and greed.

¹ Dolan, B. (2022). *Main Characteristics of Capitalist Economies*. [online] Investopedia.

The 17th-century political philosopher Thomas Hobbes lived during the English Civil War, a time of great political upheaval, in which these turbulent times of violent conflict greatly influenced his theory on human nature, the role of government and the necessity of social order. In his seminal work "Leviathan," published in 1651, Hobbes famously describes the state of nature, the existence of humans without political association or human intervention, as a condition of "war of every man against every man", where life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short"². This Hobbesian view on human nature may be accurately seen through the toilet paper shortages during the COVID-19 pandemic, with individuals working against each other to stockpile toilet paper to prevent others from accessing it. Through this, it can be argued the first image of my stimulus portrays the Hobbesian nature of man in our perpetual state of war.

Consequently, to escape our dark human nature, Hobbes posits the necessity of a sovereign leader to provide a strong central authority to maintain order and prevent conflict. He argues that citizens obey and are willing to sign the 'social contract' as the state of nature is so appalling. Hobbes' argument that individuals are primarily motivated by self-interest and the pursuit of personal gain, mirrors that of the principles of capitalism as individuals are encouraged to pursue their economic self-interest to compete with others in the free market. Thus, it can be argued that capitalism drives economic growth through harnessing the Hobbesian self-interested motives of self-preservation to ensure survival. Moreover, his advocacy for a strong central authority to maintain order is connected to the role of strong government interventions in a capitalist economic system (e.g. market regulation and tax subsidies). The capitalist system thrives in a stable and predictable environment in which Hobbes' sovereign leader provides its absolute authority; without a central authority to prevent conflicts and enforce laws, the potential for disruptions to economic activities would increase significantly.

In significant contrast to Hobbes' view on human nature, 18th-century Swiss philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau believed the system of capitalism does not amplify the worst aspects of human nature. Rousseau proposed that individuals were once 'noble savages' born good and happy but as we

² Hobbes, T. & A., G.J.C., 2008. *Leviathan*, New York: Oxford University Press

emerged from the state of nature and joined society, we became plagued by vice and sin. Rousseau firmly believed this as having grown up in poverty, he witnessed inequality's effects on his native city, which was transitioning from a feudal to a capitalist economy. Through this, Rousseau coined the term "Amour-propre" which describes how the march towards civilisation had awakened a form of self-love that was artificial and centred around pride, jealousy and vanity³. Rousseau's line of thinking becomes even clearer when applied to the stimulus: the image of the carefree Park family in their magnificent home displays the modern decadence that has plagued us. Nonetheless, some would argue that this overwhelmingly positive outlook on human nature is just an idealisation of small, homogenous communities, although it can be argued that these communities would be the closest representation to the 'state of nature'. Through this, I believe his theory completely romanticises primitive cultures, which contrasts his view on the goodness of human nature as these primitive cultures still committed acts of 'sin' against each other. Therefore, how can human nature be good if uncivilised cultures still commit documented acts of evil such as cannibalism? It is evident through Rousseau's view on human nature that capitalism does not exemplify the natural goodness and cooperative tendencies he attributed to humans in their state of nature. Instead, he saw capitalism as a departure from human nature, fostering selfishness, inequality, and exploitation.

Moreover, in direct opposition to the capitalist idea of the ownership of assets, Rousseau thought man had no right to property, he believed the introduction of private property was a pivotal moment in human history that marked the onset of inequality and the corruption of human nature³. This is because before the establishment of civil society, individuals lived in a simple and egalitarian manner, with common ownership of resources, which resulted in fewer social disparities. The possessive notion of "mine" and "thine" created from the selfishness of owning property, he saw as contributing to the erosion of natural compassion and empathy among human beings. Nonetheless, I find this argument misguided and circular as animals in the state of nature have distinct qualities of possession, particularly in; mating, territory, and the right to capture or kill. Thus, how does the ownership of property lead to the erosion of human nature if the trait of ownership is inherent to the state of nature?

³ Rousseau, J.-J. (2001). *The Social Contract*. Paris: Gf Flammarion.

Regardless, it is evident that excess ownership leads to inequality as evidently seen in the monopoly of the oil trade, companies such as OPEC distribute the majority of the world's oil assets⁴, thus having complete market dominance to manipulate prices to their advantage and away from the needs of the public.

Karl Marx similarly argued that capitalism fundamentally contradicts human nature and leads to exploitation, alienation, and class struggle. Marx was a German philosopher and economist who witnessed the rapid industrialization of the 19th century which transformed the socio-economic landscape of Europe. As a result, Marx rejected the idea of a timeless and immutable essence of human nature, asserting that human beings are shaped by the socio-economic conditions and historical context in which they live⁵. Consequently, in his works "Economic and Philosophic Manuscript of 1844" and "Capital", he argued that capitalism perpetuates alienation and exploitation of the working class, which he believed to be intrinsic to the capitalist mode of production. According to Marx, capitalism encourages selfishness, competition, and the commodification of human labour, leading to a fragmented and unequal society. He saw capitalism as a system that distorts genuine human nature, promoting a materialistic and dehumanising way of life⁵.

From a Marxist lens, the contrast of rich and poor demonstrates his theory of capitalism as a system of inherent class conflict, with the capitalist Park family and working-class Kim family pitted against each other in a struggle for wealth. Therefore, it moulds human nature to serve the interests of minority capital contributors at the expense of the working class. In spite of this, Marx envisioned a post-capitalist society where the means of production are collectively owned by the working class, leading to a classless society where human potential can be fully realised⁶. In such a utopian society, Marx believed that true human nature, characterised by genuine cooperation uninfluenced by monetary considerations, could be realized without the constraints imposed by capitalism. I find this

⁴ Chestney, N., Astakhova, O. and Chestney, N. (2023). What is OPEC+ and how does it impact oil prices? *Reuters*.

⁵ Maïa Pal (2018). *Introducing Marxism in International Relations Theory*. [online] E-International Relations.

⁶ Marx, K. and Engels, F. (1848). *Communist Manifesto*. J E Burghard.

view most convincing as it uniquely answers my question as capitalism distorting human nature, not amplifying the worst aspects as he believed human nature was neither 'good' nor 'bad' in a moral sense. Whereas previously discussed philosophers have a grounded vision of what human nature is, I enjoy the flexibility of Marx's view and its approach of utilising historical materialism which allows my question to be answered across all cultures and communities as it accounts for diverse societies, allowing the theories of a western philosopher to be applied to the East Asian background of my stimulus.

Finally, in opposition to Rousseau and Marx, the philosophical ideas of Hobbes inspired the works of Adam Smith, who argued that capitalism positively exemplifies human nature. Smith argued that capitalism aligns with self-interested aspects and individualistic aspects of human nature; similar to the perspective of Hobbes, yet contrastingly he sees selfishness as a trait to exploit, as "Individual ambition serves the common good". Smith explains this notion in his work "The Wealth of Nations," where he famously explains the concept of the "invisible hand," where individuals, motivated by their human nature of self-interest, unintentionally contribute to the overall economic well-being of society⁷. This is because the pursuit of individual gain leads to increased competition among producers and sellers, which, in turn, tends to drive prices down and improve the quality of goods and services. On the one hand, many see this argument favourably as it resonates with a common motivation driving everyday people to work harder to achieve a better quality of life; although in pursuits someone inevitably loses out of your gain, many deem this acceptable if the gain benefits themselves and their larger community. On the other hand, this theory left unregulated leads to extreme inequality as displayed in the stimulus; when individuals pursue their self-interest, those with greater wealth and resources (analogous to the grand architecture of the second image) may have a competitive advantage, leading to an accumulation of wealth among a few, while others struggle to meet basic needs (resembling the broken home of the first image).

⁷ Smith, A. (2009). *The Wealth of Nations*. Lexington, Ky.: Seven Treasures Publications.

Furthermore, Smith argues in our instinctive quest for profits, capitalist producers also expand their businesses and invest in new technologies to become more efficient. This is because rivalry provides an incentive for improvement which motivates us to continuously improve products and services; the human condition of competition drives a monopoly development which is seen all around us. This innovation and expansion contribute to economic growth, increased productivity, and the creation of new job opportunities⁸. Altogether, Smith highlights Hobbes' argument of our innate selfishness, however, I agree there is a way to manipulate greed in a positive light although greed is a negative trait of human nature. Nonetheless, as showcased in my stimulus, greed can expand in excess, generating uncontrollable inequality as demonstrated in the contrasting standard of living between the two families.

In conclusion, I believe Marx has the most convincing response to the notion of capitalism amplifying the worst aspects of human nature as I agree in not making absolute moral judgments, instead emphasising the influence of socioeconomic systems on human behaviour, and recognising the relevance of history and culture is necessary to understanding the errors in political systems.

Furthermore, the arguments of Hobbes and Rousseau have too many fundamental flaws and circularity objections to rectify their theories. Smith's argument, although persuasive in many ways, feels too far from human understanding of behaviour to be persuasive enough to align with an economic system; greed, although intrinsic to our human condition, is not sustainable in excess. Personally, I struggle to accept the idea that the system creating such horror in the first stimulus image has a benefit to our society, particularly as 'Parasite' portrays South Korea's modern-day society and mirrors the deepening inequality of the world as a whole. Nevertheless, utilising Marx's theory, although capitalism is amplifying the worst selfish aspects of human nature, a change characterised by greater compassion could evolve our human nature in response to these changes. It is for these reasons that Marx's notion of capitalism moulding a negative human nature offers the most convincing argument for my philosophical question.

⁸ Boushey, H. and Knudsen, H. (2021). *The Importance of Competition for the American Economy*. [online] The White House.

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